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A Magazine of Record and Review

VOL. X. No. 1. "I have gathered me a posie of other men's flowers, and nothing, . . . but the thread that binds them is mine own."—Montaigne MAY, 1892

CURRENT FACT AND OPINION

AMERICA IN ENGLAND

Under title of *An Unknown Country*, the last literary work of an American writer, Alexander Augustus Hayes, who died in Paris on April 17th, appears in the April Westminster Review. It takes the English to task for their insular ignorance of the United States, a state of mind which has become historic. At the same time, he pleads, in view of their great financial interests in this country, for a stimulation of English interest in our institutions. In proof of his assertions regarding the widespread ignorance which exists, he avoids citing old and well-known instances, but illustrates it by examples which have come under his personal knowledge.

"Within a few months," he says, "an eminent Englishman of letters printed in London an account, fairly bristling with amusing mistakes, of his own trip across our continent. I cannot epitomize or illustrate them better than by supposing an American to say that he had gone from Plymouth to Inverness by the South-Eastern Railway, and greatly admired *en route* the scenery of Hertfordshire and Norfolk. Yet this genial and accomplished gentleman was on the ground himself, and, if he could do no better than this, what are the mistakes continually made in the matter of American geography by those who write on this side of the water? To chronicle them would be monotonous; to try to correct them, hopeless. I think, however, that nothing in this regard comes up to the achievement of a most courteous and open-minded Englishman who crossed the Atlantic with the intention of familiarizing himself with the New World. He carried letters to an

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less for pertinacity. When they are elderly and unprepossessing, this pertinacity is nothing less than impudence. The modest tourist does not know how to deal with them. If they pin two bouquets into his coat while he is strenuously declaring he does not want a single flower, he can only get out of the dilemma with honor by pressing a franc into his tormentor's palm and giving her a look of appeal which shall, he hopes, secure him immunity in the future. Vain aspiration! The next day sees the same toils woven about him, and again he falls a victim. Perhaps it will be asked "Why in the name of common sense spend hours in the cafés of Venice, which might be so profitably employed elsewhere?" Echo answers, "Why, indeed?" It is enough that one does it, and feels little or no shame in the deed. Besides, it must not be supposed that in Venice it is always fine weather, and that every night there is a sweet romantic calm, with a lustrous moon pendant overhead to illumine you in your gondola. Oh, dear, no! Sometimes the rain here is very bad, and there are days in spring when you would hail the temperature of London during a March northeaster as a merciful exchange. The idea of a gondola under these conditions is preposterous. Moreover, it must be remembered that the intelligent traveller travels to see varieties of life, as well as pictures and buildings and scenery. For variety of scene these cafés are matchless. They are no mean education for the man who has seeing eyes and an absorbent brain. This is sufficient justification for them.

THE ISLE OF SKULLS....SAN FRANCISCO EXAMINER

On the lonely, wind-swept island of San Nicolas, eighty miles off the coast of Ventura County, where, as far back as the memory of man runs, hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides, local archæologists are now busy gathering the relics of a strange, extinct race. The island is ten miles long and oval in shape, being four miles across at the widest part. Strange utensils of serpentine, sandstone, and steatite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its erstwhile inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension. In 1835 the *padres* of Santa Barbara, learning that there were but sixteen of the strange Indian race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over

in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and, one of the frequent storms of the channel islands springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conception and all on board were lost. Sixteen years later Capt. George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt otter off San Nicolas. On landing, they were, like Crusoe, astonished to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea. It was two years thereafter that the adventurous captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman with long, tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of colored bird-skins, and scraping with a bone knife the blubber from a seal. They surrounded and approached her stealthily, and, although suddenly confronted, she did not appear in the least afraid, but smiled, and then, falling on her knees, prayed to the sun. The wild woman offered no objection when by signs she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat. They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr. S. L. Shaw, now 80 years old and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen nor heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race forever. Wild dogs had eaten her child. Her dress of red and blue feathers, a wonderful creation of barbaric hands, was sent to the Pope of Rome. Relic hunters have gathered mortars, pestles, ollas, toy steatite canoes, and other curious things there for some years past, and shipped them to various Eastern and European universities. Skeletons and parts of skeletons have also been collected in large numbers, but to-day the bones of thousands of Indians are scattered about there. Some lie face down, indicating that they have fallen in battle. There are so many human relics there that San Nicolas is known as the

Isle of Skulls. "The lonely island, whose highest part is but 1,040 feet above the sea," said a resident of Ventura recently, "is noted for the high artistic class of many of its relics. Had the woman rescued, then 52 years old, not died, a story passing strange would no doubt have been told of the race so long hemmed in by the waste of waters about. As it is, much of the story is shrouded in mystery forever."

THE NOBLE GAME OF GOLF....DANSHEE....NEW YORK SUN

It is estimated that some 35,000 persons play golf, more or less skilfully, in the world. England is studded with commons, and it is astonishing to note what a value has suddenly been set upon these bleak spots, the existence of which a few years ago was scarcely recognized. Every week witnesses the establishment of at least one club; and the other day a well-known professional took boat for the Isle of Man on a commission to lay out four links at once. A gentlemen's park will soon be considered incomplete unless it has its golf course, though few parks are fit for the purpose on account of the long grass; and it is rarely indeed that a ladies' course is not laid out at the same time. The reason why all the best links are on the seashore is because there the soil is sandy and light, and grows the proper kind of turf. The turf should be very short and close, so that a ball lying upon it presents a fair mark for the club. The ground should be undulating without being hilly, and, if possible, varied in character. That is to say, there should be patches of lawn-like smoothness for the putting greens (where they do not exist they must be made), and other patches of sand and bad ground, with various growths upon them. Coming to such a spot, it is the business of the designer of the links to place his holes about in such a way that they are separated by distances varying from 200 to 400 yards, or even more, according to the space at disposal, and also present to the accurate player a "course" which, if properly kept, is free from vexations. The patches of sand, long grass, broken ground, bushes, heath, etc., are traps, and cost strokes—the object, of course, being to go from hole to hole in the fewest strokes. Golf balls have exercised the ingenuity of makers a good deal. Immense numbers are used, and the item is a very serious one to a golfer, who cannot play a good game with bad balls. The average price of a ball is one shilling (the